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## A Hamitic kingdom in the center of Africa

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### Section Title(S)

Book IV (First Fascicle) The Royal Court (Its Posts, Privileges, Mores, and Customs)

One sees standing about what seem to be huge baskets covered with thatch roofs. They are granaries where the food of the employees is kept. The storeroom is the king's favorite spot. He takes pleasure in hoarding there the most disparate objects: fabrics, crockery, furniture, and trinkets of all sorts. It is said that it gives him infinite pleasure to survey his "bazaar" and to handle the goods piece by piece, away from all prying eyes.

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It is easy to imagine the life and bustle that prevail at court and in the capital.

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The entire nation dwells in the person of the king. He alone represents it. Since the State is identified with the king, he alone is eternally mentioned. "Everything is done for his sake. Justice is the king's justice, troops are the king's army, the nobility fights for him.... The monarch is absolute master and naturally has full and complete command over the property owned by his subjects, and when he takes it he is only taking what belongs to him.... Whoever is born a subject must obey without question...."

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This short account of the history of Louis XIV's reign fittingly describes the rights exercised by the Hamitic kings of Ruanda. As a result of this concept

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and attitude on the part of the Blacks, nearly all the clans or family groups which make up the population of Ruanda have a role to fulfill at court, not so much for the welfare of the realm as for the pleasure of the king. The functions they must exercise are many and vary with the nature of the people involved and the products of the soil on which they live. Some of the posts derive from historical circumstances. Among these offices, some are regarded as an honor and privilege and others as a chore. Some offices are also assigned as punishment or 352 revenge for misdeeds which were committed in the past by ancestors and the very memory of which has been lost. Most of those posts amount to actual bondage for their holders.

Positions of a mere utilitarian nature are by far the most numerous.

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It is surprising to hear that literary pleasures and entertainments are included in the court program and even stand in a separate category. By the sovereign's side, indeed, there stand official historians and 80 appointed bards (*abachurabgenge*), as well as literary jousters or men of choice language called *Abasizi*, whose only role is to refresh the king's memory or to beguile his leisure with tasteful improvisations. Even the commoners are not insensitive to literature. There is not a single Munyarwanda /Banyarwanda/ who is not keenly interested in the legends, narratives, fables, moral or humorous tales, riddles, plays on words, jokes, etc., belonging to the oral literature.

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